Biographical Issue Appeals and Legislative Follow-Through

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Abstract

Scholars frequently view the rise of personalistic politics as a threat to programmatic representation. This paper challenges that narrative by introducing biographical issue appeals—campaign messages that explicitly link a candidate's personal experiences to specific issue positions. Using a supervised machine learning classifier on U.S. House campaign websites (2018–2022), I find that biographical issue appeals are a prolific messaging strategy, employed by 68% of candidates, especially those in competitive districts and high-quality candidates. Drawing on a theory of credible commitment, I argue that biographical issue appeals function as high-intensity signals of legislative intent. I test the mechanisms and trade-offs of these signals through a survey experiment, examining how voters weigh increased perceptions of competence and commitment against the constraints of a candidate's limited attention. Finally, analysis of original cosponsorships reveals that these appeals are strong predictors of actual legislative follow-through. These findings suggest that personalism can facilitate democratic accountability by providing an informational anchor to discern a candidate's true legislative priorities.

Across the globe, contemporary politics is increasingly characterized as personalistic rather than programmatic, with individual candidates playing a heightened role relative to political parties and party platforms (e.g. Garzia 2014; Rahat 2014). In these personalized environments, candidates rely more heavily on their own characteristics, experiences, and identities to communicate with and persuade voters. Many scholars suggest that this shift toward personalized politics is normatively problematic, suggesting it weakens democratic representation by encouraging voters to focus on candidate personality rather than policy or party platforms (e.g. Rahat and Kenig 2018). Some scholars argue that increased personalism brings an increased risk of not only political polarization, but even democratic decline and collapse (Rhodes-Purdy and Madrid 2020; Frantz et al. 2021, p. 96).

In the United States, parties have traditionally been considered to be programmatic, especially considering the resurgence of party polarization and nationalized voting behavior (Jacobson 2015). However, the Democratic and Republican parties compete as a collection of individual candidates, and there is still substantial evidence that candidate-centered politics plays an important role in elections at both the presidential and congressional levels (e.g. Wattenberg 1991; Porter and Treul 2024). Candidates consistently seek to cultivate personal reputations and individualized electoral support (Fenno 1977; Cain, Ferejohn and Fiorina 1987), and this has persisted, and perhaps even intensified, in an era of strong parties and political polarization (e.g. McGhee and Pearson 2017).

Taken together, scholarship on the personalization of politics and the candidate-centered nature of politics in the U.S. seems to suggest a normative concern: that candidates who engage in personalized campaign appeals will ultimately undermine representation and democratic accountability if elected to office. Yet, candidates frequently use their background, previous occupations, and personal experiences to persuade voters to support them in elections (e.g. McDonald, Porter and Treul 2020). This presents an critical question: does the use of personalized rhetoric in campaign communication enhance or undermine representation?

I argue that personalized appeals serve as a credible signal of commitment to issue prior-

itization if elected. This argument builds on research demonstrating that campaign appeals are not merely "cheap talk" but are meaningful precursors to legislative action (Sulkin 2009). I extend this logic by introducing the concept of biographical issue appeals, defined as instances where candidates invoke their own personal experiences in conjunction with a policy position. While we know candidates use their backgrounds to establish general likability (Arbour and McGowen 2017), biographical issue appeals go a step further by explicitly using a candidate's history to strengthen a policy promise. In this sense, the importance of biographical issue appeals lies not just in what issues a candidate chooses to discuss, but in how they frame those issues. By anchoring a policy position in a specific personal history, a candidate creates a high-intensity signal that differentiates her specific priorities from standard party rhetoric and demonstrates commitment and competence to potential voters.

In this paper, I assess the strategic use and representative consequences of these appeals by addressing three primary questions: (1) when and who uses biographical issue appeals, (2) do voters perceive biographical issue appeals as signals of commitment and competence, and (3) do candidates who use biographical issue appeals actually follow through on them once in office?

To answer these questions, I utilize a supervised machine learning classifier on a dataset of U.S. House campaign websites from 2018–2022 (Porter, Case and Treul 2025). I find that biographical issue appeals are a highly prevalent campaign stategy, utilized by 68% of candidates. In line with a theory of strategic signaling, candidates in competitive districts, strong fundraisers, and those with previous political experience are significantly more likely to use these appeals. Furthermore, I demonstrate that these appeals have tangible legislative consequences: candidates who utilize biographical issue appeals are more likely to follow through on those specific issues in Congress than those who do not. Finally, using a survey experiment, I examine whether biographical issue appeals successfully enhance a candidate's perceived competence and commitment in the eyes of voters, and whether these appeals also carry trade-offs regarding a candidate's perceived focus on alternative issues.

By demonstrating that biographical issue appeals serve as a credible commitment to future legislative effort, this paper suggests that the personalization of politics does not necessarily come at the expense of substantive representation and democratic accountability. Ultimately, these findings indicate that personal narratives in campaign communications provide an essential informational anchor, allowing voters to discern which policy commitments a candidate is most likely to prioritize once in office.

Campaigns and Candidate-Centered Issue Messaging

When on the campaign trail, candidates attempt to communicate information to potential voters in order to attract enough support to win a primary and general election contest. Political campaigns are a mechanism through which candidates try to distinguish themselves from their competitors, share their agenda, and persuade voters (Druckman, Kifer and Parkin 2009). A plethora of political science literature is dedicated to studying what issues congressional candidates should campaign on to enhance their electoral prospects. Some scholars suggest that candidates should focus on party-owned issues (Petrocik 1996; Spiliotes and Vavreck 2002), while others suggest running on issues that are highly salient to voters, regardless of party ownership (Ansolabehere and Iyengar 1994; Kaplan, Park and Ridout 2006).

Beyond choosing what issues to run on, candidates also have significant leeway in how they choose to message on those issues. Through various forms of communication, such as campaign websites, social media, and television advertisements, candidates utilize a wide variety of strategies, including negative appeals (Lau, Sigelman and Rovner 2007; Geer 2008), emotional targeting (Brader 2006; Albertson, Dun and Gadarian 2020), or delivery through trusted messengers (Zaller 1992; Iyengar and Valentino 2000; Searles, Spencer and Duru 2020). Yet, one strategy that is understudied is how candidates use their own backgrounds to anchor their issue positions. This is surprising considering that candidates

typically convey information about both their biography and their issue positions simultaneously; nearly one-third of congressional candidates use biographical info in TV ads (Arbour and McGowen 2017), and over 70% of primary candidates utilize a biography page alongside an issue platform on their websites (Porter, Case and Treul 2025).

I introduce the concept of biographical issue appeals (BIAs), which I define as instances where candidates invoke specific personal experiences or professional backgrounds in conjunction with an issue position. While candidates often share biographical information and issue stances separately, a biographical issue appeal explicitly fuses the two. The importance of this strategy lies not just in the issue content (e.g. which issue a candidate discusses), but in the delivery: a biographical issue appeal communicates information about a candidate's background and/or personal experiences. To illustrate the difference between a standard issue appeal and a biographical issue appeal, consider the contrast between two candidates messaging on healthcare in 2018. Todd Allen, a Democratic candidate running in Texas' 24th district included the below statement on healthcare on his campaign website:

> "60,000. In just the 24th District, that is the number of Americans who would lose healthcare coverage under the Republican House plan energetically supported by our current representative. Most of us would agree that healthcare insurance premiums are too high and that the cost of coverage is hurting more American families that it heals." – Todd Allen campaign website

Allen's campaign statement on healthcare is an example of a standard issue appeal that does not invoke his own personal experience. Instead, he directly attacks the Republican healthcare plan and the (Republican) incumbent representative in the district through this issue messaging on healthcare. Kevin Abel, a Democratic candidate in Georgia's 6th district, provides a contrasting example. Abel's healthcare statement on his campaign website reads:

> "Healthcare is a right. All Americans must have access to quality, affordable care. After two decades of providing healthcare to hundreds of employees right here in the 6th District, I know that it's like to deal with double digit premium increases every year. As a cancer survivor, I know what it's like to worry more about your medical bill than your diagnosis." – Kevin Abel campaign website

In this statement on healthcare, Kevin Abel makes two references to his biography, one related to his background as a healthcare provider and a second revealing his status as a cancer survivor. In contrast to Allen's strategy of partisan attack, Abel uses his biography as a means for underscoring his policy promise. I argue that biographical issue appeals, such as Abel's, function as a high-intensity signal of commitment to working on a specific issue. While existing scholarship suggests that the issues candidates prioritize on the campaign trail are meaningfully related to their activity once in office (Sulkin 2009), I posit that biographical issue appeals elevate both the signal that candidates are sending to voters and their actual commitment to working on an issue.

BIAs as Signals of Competence and Commitment

I argue that biographical issue appeals operate through two primary mechanisms: demonstrating competence in handling and commitment to addressing specific issues. Evaluating these mechanisms is essential because, as a long line of research has shown, persuasion in campaigns is notoriously difficult; most voters rely heavily on partisan identification when evaluating candidates (Campbell et al. 1960; Green, Palmquist and Schickler 2002; Hewitt et al. 2024). Consequently, political campaigns rarely change the minds of voters. Instead, they are more effective at raising the salience of different considerations that lead voters to support one candidate over another (Iyengar and Kinder 1987; Zaller 1992). One way candidates do this is by attempting to raise the salience of issues that make them look strong. While candidates often choose to message on issues "owned" by their party (Petrocik 1996) or those especially salient to the electorate (Ansolabehere and Iyengar 1994), candidates also focus on issues that make themselves as an individual look strong (Sellers 1998). Sellers (1998) finds that candidates perform better among voters when they campaign on issues for which they have a personal background. Biographical issue appeals provide a vehicle for candidates to demonstrate that they possess this relevant experience, and are therefore

competent in handling an issue.

The effectiveness of this strategy is rooted in the psychological power of the personal appeal. To the extent that persuasion in politics is possible, research suggests that personal narratives are a particularly potent form of communication (Kalla and Broockman 2020; Kubin et al. 2021; Naunov, Rueda-Canon and Ryan 2025). In the context of citizen-to-citizen persuasion, Naunov, Rueda-Canon and Ryan (2025) find that personal narrative communication far outperforms messages that rely simply on facts or generic appeals. Similarly, Kubin et al. (2021) present compelling evidence that sharing personal experiences is successful in bridging moral divides and reducing political animus. Biographical issue appeals leverage these dynamics by explicitly linking a candidate's history to their position on a specific issue, thereby adding a personal touch that voters perceive as less manipulative than standard campaign rhetoric. Because people are less likely to doubt or argue against stories conveying a lived experience (Green and Brock 2000), these appeals are viewed as more credible signals of a candidate's qualifications.

By explicitly linking their background to their position on a specific issue, candidates can add a personal touch that provides evidence for that candidate's competence. Biographical issue appeals are signals that the candidate possesses the ground-level experience or expertise required to navigate complex policy. For instance, both elites and ordinary citizens associate specific occupations with competence; Fong (2020) finds that even members of Congress regularly take cues from peers who have professional expertise they themselves lack. Among voters, Costa and Pereira (2025) finds that legislators with previous occupational experience in fields like education or healthcare are perceived as more credible and are more effective at persuading voters on related policy issues. This suggests that voters interpret professional and personal backgrounds as meaningful signals of a candidate's ability to handle specific issues.

Beyond establishing expertise, biographical issue appeals allow a candidate to demonstrate a credible commitment to prioritizing specific issues if elected. Despite finding that

campaigns are credible signals of issue prioritization, Sulkin (2009) comments that there is a persistent narrative among voters and in the media that candidates will say whatever it takes in order to get elected and then fail to follow through on those promises. One way in which candidates might try to avoid this accusation is by demonstrating that their policy goals are not merely opportunistic, but are rooted in their sincerely held beliefs and life experiences.

By tying a policy to their own life story, a candidate signals to voters that the issue is a primary focus. Consistent with Fenno (1978), congressional candidates might engage in biographical issue appeals to demonstrate to potential voters "I am one of you" or "I care about the same issues that you do." While Fenno (1978) highlights this as a way to build trust, in the context of a biographical issue appeal, this "one of us" identity acts as a bond of commitment. When a candidate uses their background as a veteran, a small business owner, or a cancer survivor to explain a policy position, they are essentially offering their life story as a warranty for their future behavior. They signal that their commitment to the issue is intrinsic rather than tactical, making it harder for the candidate to shirk that issue once in office without incurring a significant reputational cost to their personal identity.

Furthermore, this commitment signal is reinforced by the logic of legislative prioritization. Because political capital and legislative time are finite, voters must decide which of a candidate's many promises are likely to be pursued. By leaning in to a biographical experience, a candidate can signal a hierarchy of legislative intent, suggesting that these issues will receive their attention, which can be a scarce resource in Congress. Existing research shows empirical support for this mechanism; that legislators with relevant professional experience exhibit substantively different behavior once in office. For example, Fountaine, Shepherd and Skinner (2024) find that physician members of Congress are more likely to work on healthcare legislation and are more legislatively effective on health care policy relative to non-physician members. This pattern of legislative behavior provides voters with a rational basis for associating biographical issue appeals with actual commitment. Taken together, these factors suggest that biographical issue appeals serve as a powerful signaling device

that reinforces the representative link by demonstrating that a candidate's policy agenda is an extension of their personal and professional history.

Strategic Use of Biographical Issue Appeals

Given that biographical issue appeals may serve as potential signals of competence and commitment, the decision for candidates to use them is likely a strategic one that is shaped by the electoral environment and the characteristics of the individual candidate. Beginning with electoral conditions, I expect that candidates running in competitive districts will be more likely to incorporate BIAs into their campaign communications. In competitive districts, candidates may not be able to rely only on copartisans to secure victory. Instead, they may have to rally support from independents and persuade voters from the opposing party to cast a ballot in their favor. To do this, candidates will want to enhance their likability and demonstrate competence and commitment in order to persuade voters.

As noted previously, personal narrative communication is the most effective way to engage in meaningful persuasion (Naunov, Rueda-Canon and Ryan 2025). Following this, it is likely that candidates adopt this strategy to distinguish themselves in tight races. A candidate sharing about their own background can enhance their likability, particularly among independents and opposing partisans, more effectively than an impersonal campaign message or one that focuses strictly on partisan attacks. In a competitive election, a strategy that emphasizes shared experience and personal stakes is likely to alienate fewer voters while leaving a more favorable impression. In competitive districts, candidates need to be wary of alienating potential voters and work to attract support from both sides of the aisle. Specifically, I expect:

> *H1*: Candidates in competitive electoral districts are more likely to engage in biographical issue appeals in their campaign rhetoric than candidates in safe districts.

Furthermore, I expect that candidate characteristics will be related to the likelihood that candidates engage in biographical issue appeals. High-quality candidates differ from their counterparts primarily in their campaign resources and the resulting level of professionalization. Candidates with more resources and more professional campaigns are more likely to have the ability to conduct expensive pre-tests of their messaging strategies to identify the most persuasive and effective campaign communications (Hewitt et al. 2024). This pre-testing process, which allows candidates to fine-tune personal narratives to resonate with specific electorates, is likely not available to candidates without vast resources on hand or professionalized campaign organizations. Beyond financial resources, candidates with previous political experience have already navigated at least one successful campaign. As a result, they are more likely to possess a robust campaign infrastructure and a seasoned understanding of which messaging strategies, particularly those that leverage their specific expertise and background, resonate most effectively with the electorate. Given the existing evidence in political behavior that personal appeals are a uniquely persuasive messaging strategy, I expect that candidates with the resources and experience to devote significant time and money to crafting these complex narratives will be more likely to utilize BIAs.

This expectation aligns with two traditional measures of candidate quality: candidate experience and campaign finances (Jacobson 1989; Bond, Covington and Fleisher 1985). While recent work has shown that voters may be increasingly open to a broader range of background experiences for congressional candidates (Porter and Treul 2024), fundraising remains a critical marker of whether a candidate is a viable competitor (Maestas and Rugeley 2008; Bonica 2017). Scholars such as Maestas and Rugeley (2008) have demonstrated that candidates without prior political experience can still demonstrate their seriousness and viability through fundraising efforts, and these resources are often what enable the professionalized messaging described above. Therefore, I define high-quality candidates in terms of both resources and previous elected experience, and I expect:

H2: Candidates with more resources (as measured through campaign fundrais-

ing) and candidates with previous elected experience (incumbents and experienced challengers) will be more likely to utilize biographical issue appeals in their campaign rhetoric.

Relatedly, I also expect that incumbent candidates will engage in biographical issue appeals less than experienced challenger candidates. Incumbents and challengers differ on a number of dimensions, including their campaign strategies and rhetoric (Druckman, Kifer and Parkin 2020; Sachleben and Treul 2026). For example, incumbents dedicate more time to discussing their elected experience and their specific actions taken for constituents, while challengers dedicate more time to discussing general competence and specific issue positions (Druckman, Kifer and Parkin 2009).

All candidates want to signal their ability to function effectively as a legislator. However, none is as straightforward as engaging in credit claiming (Mayhew 1974). When incumbents engage in credit claiming, they highlight their legislative record and accomplishments as a sign of successfully performing the duties of the office. Non-incumbent candidates, who cannot rely on a record in Congress, must demonstrate competence in some other way—most notably by highlighting how their biography or professional resume prepares them for the job. Because experienced challengers have a background to draw upon but lack a congressional record, they are more incentivized to use biographical issue appeals as a proxy for that record to demonstrate competence and commitment. This leads me to hypothesize that:

H3: Experienced challenger candidates are more likely to utilize biographical issue appeals in their campaign rhetoric than incumbent candidates.

Overall, I expect that both electoral characteristics, such as the competitiveness of a district, and candidate characteristics, such as the quality of a candidate, are related to the frequency with which candidates leverage biographical issue appeals in their campaign communication.

Voter Perceptions of Biographical Issue Appeals

While evaluating which candidates utilize biographical issue appeals as a messaging strategy is important in its own right, campaigns are fundamentally oriented toward the persuasion and mobilization of voters. This necessitates an examination of how these signals are received. Because voters cannot know for certain if a candidate will actually prioritize an issue once in office, they must rely on available cues to assess future behavior. I expect that biographical issue appeals function as high-intensity signals of both competence and commitment.

By invoking these personal experiences, candidates encourage voters to perceive campaign promises not as generic statements but as credible, issue-specific commitments. By anchoring policy in lived experience, candidates leverage a form of experiential authority that is effective at building credibility (Costa and Pereira 2025). This personalized approach provides a rationale for policy that is rooted in individual experience rather than abstract data, encouraging voters to view a candidate's experience as a meaningful signal of priorities. This leads to the following expectations regarding voter evaluations:

> *H4*: Candidates utilizing a biographical issue appeal for a specific issue will be perceived as more competent in and more committed to handling that issue than candidates who present the same issue position without a BIA.

If biographical issue appeals consistently enhance perceptions of a candidate's competence and committment to working on an issue, it raises a critical question: why would any candidate *not* leverage these appeals in their campaign communications? Part of this is likely driven by the resource constraints and differences in candidate quality that were previously discussed; however, I argue that candidates also engage in strategic selectivity to avoid potential negative, and unintended, consequences of biographical issue appeals.

Candidates are cognizant that biographical information acts as a heuristic that conveys information beyond what the candidate explicitly intends to reveal. Existing literature demonstrates that traits such as gender, race, and social class carry additional ideological

perceptions; for instance, women and Black candidates are often perceived as more liberal than white males (McDermott 1998), and candidates from working-class backgrounds are similarly perceived as more liberal than their peers (Carnes and Sadin 2015).

These cues extend to occupational backgrounds as well. As Kirkland and Coppock (2017) demonstrate, voters use occupation to infer ideology, often perceiving small business owners as more conservative and educators as more liberal. If a candidate wishes to avoid being stereotyped into an ideological corner that may be disadvantageous in their district, they may choose to avoid biographical issue appeals that may contain these unintentional ideological cues. Furthermore, regardless of the ideological cues they convey, certain candidate backgrounds may not help a candidate's electoral success, and therefore a candidate may avoid leaning into that background. For example, working class candidates tend to perform poorly in primary elections (Treul and Hansen 2023), which may lead those candidates to avoid leaning into their identity and experience as a working class person. Overall, there is evidence to suggest that biographical issue appeals may convey unintended signals beyond the explicit words that the candidate uses. Specifically I hypothesize:

> *H5*: The use of a biographical issue appeal will shift voter perceptions of a candidate's ideological placement based on the heuristics associated with the invoked background.

Beyond ideological stereotyping, candidates must contend with the fact that voters may view commitment as a scarce resource. In the legislative environment, members of Congress are constantly having to make tradeoffs in terms of what they prioritize. In fact, scholars such as Krehbiel (1991) suggest that Congress is specifically organized on the understanding that members cannot prioritize legislating on, or even possessing knowledge about, all issues, so members are therefore incentivized to specialize in certain issue areas. Members' time is a finite resource, and the necessity of making tradeoffs has only increased with the rise of the perpetual campaign (e.g. Lee 2016). Especially when faced with tight timelines and long omnibus bills, members' time is clearly divided and limited, and they must rely on other

mechanisms for coping with their time constraints, such as relying on party leadership for information (Curry 2015). Just as members of Congress must strategically allocate their attention, voters may be intuitively aware of these constraints and use campaign signals to infer a candidate's likely legislative agenda. If a candidate leans heavily into their background as a teacher to discuss education, a rational voter may infer that the candidate's focus lies in that domain, and they will therefore not allocate sufficient energy toward other critical areas, such as healthcare or agriculture. In this view, a biographical issue appeal acts as a signal of how a candidate will spend their limited 24-hour day in Washington. A high-intensity commitment signal to one issue area may lead voters to assume a lack of expertise or prioritization elsewhere. This creates a potential negative spillover effect where high perceived commitment in one area detracts from perceived commitment in others because issue prioritization is a zero sum game. This leads me to hypothesize:

> *H6*: Candidates utilizing a biogrphical issue appeal for a specific issue will be perceived as relatively less competent in and less committed to handling distinct, unrelated issues compared to candidates who discuss that issue same without a BIA.

Ultimately, the strategic risks and rewards of biographical issue appeals rest on the assumption that these signals are predictive of future behavior. If voters perceive biographical issue appeals as credible indicators of where a candidate's focus will lie and their ability to work on political issues, it becomes imperative to evaluate whether these campaign-season promises translate into actual legislative effort if the candidate is elected to office.

BIAs and Legislative Follow-Through

While understanding who utilizes biographical issue appeals and how they shape voter perceptions is critical, the real test of this strategy as a signal lies in whether BIAs translate into legislative action. This brings us back to the discussion about the rise of personalism in modern politics. Some scholars argue that candidate-centered, personalistic communication

distracts from programmatic policy (e.g. Rahat and Kenig 2018). If that is true, then biographical issue appeals might just be a rhetorical tool used to win elections. However, if these appeals function as signals of commitment, then personalism may actually help voters identify which policy areas a candidate is most likely to prioritize once in office.

Sulkin (2009) suggests that to evaluate whether candidates follow through on their promises, we must view campaign messaging as a roadmap for future priorities. In this framework, a candidate keeps a promise if, once in Congress, they dedicate legislative energy to the issues they emphasized on the trail. Previous scholarship provides reason for optimism; Sulkin (2009) finds that campaign rhetoric often reveals sincerely held beliefs that predict legislative prioritization, while Ringquist and Dasse (2004) demonstrates that members' roll-call behavior remains consistent with their environmental campaign messaging.

Yet, the specific type of appeal used to convey these priorities has rarely been studied. As electorally motivated individuals (Mayhew 1974), members of Congress may be incentivized to strategically leverage their backgrounds in ways that are purely beneficial for the next election (Case and Treul 2024). Given that voters often have limited knowledge of specific floor activities, members are frequently able to credit-claim or message in ways that misrepresent their actual legislative successes (Grimmer, Westwood and Messing 2014). If biographical issue appeals are merely rhetorical tactics used to win competitive races, we might expect no correlation between a candidate's BIA promises and their subsequent legislative output.

Conversely, a robust body of research suggests that the personal experiences and identities of legislators are profound drivers of their behavior in office. Burden (2007) finds that the unique backgrounds and values of members influence not only the positions they take but also how they allocate their time, a scarce resource. This is particularly evident in the literature on descriptive and substantive representation. Female legislators are more likely to champion women's interests (Reingold 2008; Cowell-Meyes and Langbein 2009), while racial minorities and veterans are more likely to work on behalf of constituents who share their identity characteristics (Lowande, Ritchie and Lauterbach 2019). Even non-traditional

backgrounds, such as being born in or near the district represented, can shift a member's focus toward constituent-heavy work rather than national policymaking (Crosson and Kaslovsky 2024).

Drawing on this work, I argue that the act of linking an issue to a biography creates a public contract that is harder to ignore than a standard policy position. If a biographical issue appeal is indeed a high-intensity signal of intent, it should predict a higher level of follow-through than generic issue messaging. Consistent with the work of Sulkin (2009) on legislative promise-keeping, I hypothesize:

> *H7*: Candidates who utilize a biographical issue appeal on an issue will be more legislatively active on that issue in office than candidates who discuss the issue without a biographical issue appeal.

Crucially, however, I posit that the choice to lean into an experience is the most potent indicator of future effort. A legislator's background is a static fact, but a campaign appeal is a strategic choice. Hundreds of candidates possess relevant professional or personal backgrounds, such as having served in the military or worked in healthcare (or having a spouse, parent, or child who has), but only a subset choose to explicitly anchor their policy platform in those experiences. While simply possessing a background may influence a legislator's worldview (Burden 2007), I argue that the act of messaging on that experience creates a specific mandate and a public expectation of prioritization. By selecting one facet of their biography to justify a policy stance, the candidate signals that this specific issue is a core priority, setting it apart from other background-consistent issues they chose to leave unmentioned. This is consistent with prior work demonstrating that voters respond not just to the cues from a candidate's background, such as being a veteran, but also to the ineraction of those cues with campaign messaging (McLaughlin, Geras and Rhinehart 2024). Overall, choosing to make a background the center of an issue appeal represents an explicit contract with the voter, which I expect to result in a higher magnitude of follow-through. This leads me to hypothesize:

H8: Candidates who choose to utilize a biographical issue appeal regarding a specific background experience will demonstrate higher levels of legislative activity on that issue than candidates who possess the same background experience but do not use a BIA.

By testing the specific effect of leaning into a candidate's biography, I can determine whether the power of the biographical appeal comes from the candidate's professional background or from the strategic commitment made during the campaign. If this hypothesis is supported, it would suggest that personalistic politics can provide a strong informational signal to voters about a candidate's legislative priorities. This would mean that these appeals are not just a distraction, but rather a high-intensity commitment that can actually be a meaningful tool for substantive representation and democratic accountability.

Data & Methods

To test the hypotheses related to candidate usage of biographical issue appeals, I conduct an analysis of campaign websites for congressional primary election candidates in the 2018, 2020, and 2022 election cycles (Porter, Case and Treul 2025). Given that I am interested in how candidates talk about issues, I utilize the text from the issues pages for each candidate.[1] In particular, campaign websites are an ideal medium through which candidates can inform voters of their positions and policy proposals for specific political issues. Furthermore, the overwhelming majority of primary election candidates have a campaign website. From 2018-2022, over 87% of candidates had a campaign website. Given this, campaign websites are well-suited for use in the study of campaign rhetoric. Candidate campaign websites typically include both biography pages and issue pages through which candidates communicate their positions on specific issues. As I am focused on understanding how candidates intertwine biography with the issue positions they take, I focus on the issue statement pages of campaign websites. Of candidates who had a campaign website from 2018 to 2022, 85% of those

[1]Specifically, this analysis includes primary election candidates who had a campaign website.

candidates included an issue platform on their website (Porter, Case and Treul 2025).

Campaign websites can act as an "information hub" for a candidate's campaign (Herrnson, Panagopoulos, and Bailey 2019), and potential voters and donors view campaign websites as a useful resource for finding out information about a candidate, especially their issue positions. After newspapers, campaign websites are the most trustworthy source that primary election voters would turn to when seeking out information about a candidate (Case, Sachleben and Treul 2025). Druckman, Kifer and Parkin (2018) find that campaign organizations see campaign websites as the best platform for capturing a candidate's overall message. Given this, candidates will dedicate significant time and resources to crafting their issue messaging strategy on their campaign websites knowing that voters, donors, and journalists may visit them to learn about the candidate (Druckman, Kifer and Parkin 2009). Sulkin, Moriarty and Hefner (2007) also conduct an analysis of campaign communications across a variety of media, such as campaign websites and televised advertisements, and find that position taking on campaign websites is consistent with other forms of campaign communication. Unlike television advertisements that can be very costly to produce and to air, campaign websites are a much cheaper and more accessible way for candidates to share their issue positions and overall message with potential supporters. Importantly, candidates can choose which issues they want to include in their campaign website and they are also free to talk about those issues in any way they would like. This means that candidates are free to present information using whatever rhetorical strategies they desire, such as biographical issue appeals. It is for these reasons that I focus on candidate campaign websites when analyzing when and how candidates engage in biographical issue appeals in their campaign communication. Overall, there were 4,506 candidates for the House of Representatives who ran in a primary election between 2018 and 2022 and who have a campaign website, and those candidates become the focus of my analysis. Altogether, these 4,506 candidates have a total of 43,465 individual issue statements.

Before evaluating which candidates engage in biographical issue appeals, it is first nec-

essary to identify these appeals in candidate issue statements. I define biographical issue appeals as instances in which a candidate discusses her background and personal experience in conjunction with her position on a particular issue. To identify biographical issue appeals, I adapt the categories laid out in Arbour and McGowen (2017), which identify several aspects of a candidate's biography that could constitute a biographical issue appeal, such as local connections to a district, references to a candidate's family, education, religion, or occupation, or stories of hardships candidates have overcome. A full description of the categories I use for defining biographical issue appeals is presented in Table 1.

Table 1: Biographical Issue Appeal Categories

Category	**Description**
Local Roots	Candidate references being born in or growing up in local region, state, or district
Parents	Candidate references their parents, grandparents, or upbringing
Family	Candidate references their spouse/partner and/or children
College	Candidate references their educational background, particularly as it relates to where they went to college or being first generation
Military	Candidate references their time serving in the military or their status as a veteran
Religion	Candidate references their religious beliefs and their practicing of those beliefs
Government	Candidate references previous government experience, either elected or unelected
Business	Candidate references their business background/business accolades
Hardship	Candidates references or describes a hardship in their life that they have overcome
Resume	Candidate references previous occupational experience outside of those listed in previous categories (e.g. being a doctor or a teacher)
Other	Candidate references other aspects of their biography or identity not captured by previous categories (e.g. being a gun owner)

Using these categories as my coding scheme, I rely on a supervised machine learning classification pipeline. I hand labeled a sample of 17,347 issue statement paragraphs for whether a candidate engaged in a biographical issue appeal in that paragraph, and divided

my hand-labled data into a training and validation set. Because the classification of biographical issue appeals is a nuanced language task, I rely on OpenAI's "text-embedding-3-small" model to generate a representation of the text for each individual issue statement paragraph using a transformer architecture. Embeddings are a numerical representation of text in a high-dimensional space that capture the overall context and semantic meaning of each issue statement paragraph. I use the embeddings for each of the paragraphs in my training data as the input for training five different machine learning models to predict whether a paragraph is a biographical issue appeal. I make out-of-sample predictions on all unlabeled issue statement paragraphs as well as a held out validation set, and I use the outputs generated by the best performing model, support vector machine (F1 = 0.784), for the subsequent analyses.[2] This then allows me to assess which candidates engage in biographical issue appeals and under what conditions.

To test the hypotheses related to voter perceptions of biographical issue appeals, I will conduct a survey experiment that presents respondents with candidate issue messaging and probes the commitment and competence mechanisms.[3] The survey is administered by Verasight and consists of a nationally representative sample of 1,500 respondents. This study employs a within-subject, randomized survey experiment. Respondents will evaluate three separate candidate statements (iterations). For each iteration, respondents are randomly assigned to either BIA Treatment (issue position with BIA) or a Control (issue position without BIA). For issue selection, issues are drawn from a pool of eight issues: education, healthcare, military, immigration, crime, guns, abortion, and agriculture. Issues are drawn without replacement across three iterations to prevent repetition, so respondents will see a total of six issues. For each iteration, respondents provide two issue-specific outcome measures: 5-point Likert scales regarding the candidate's perceived competence on an issue (i)

[2]More information on the supervised machine learning pipeline can be found in Appendix A, and validation metrics can be found in Table A5.

[3]This survey is being fielded in late May/early June. Given that I do not have data for this survey, I will not include results related to H4-H6. However, in this paragraph I include a brief overview of the experimental design.

and the candidate's perceived commitment to handling issue i. The respondent will be asked the same issue-level scales for a randomy selected different issue from the 8-issue pool (one that the candidate did not talk about). There will also be two candidate-level measures in each iteration: a 0–100 feeling thermometer and a 7-point ideological placement scale. To reduce noice from outgroup hostility, respondents will only see candidates from their own self-identified party (and pure independents will be randomized). Lastly, as a manipulation check, in one randomized iteration, respondents will be asked if the candidate discussed a personal connection to the topic.

Finally, to test my hypotheses related to biographical issue appeals and legislative follow through, I focus on introductions and cosponsorship as a measure of legislative activity, following the work of Sulkin (2009). Specifically, I focus on original cosponsorship as the primary measure of legislative activity. Although there can only be one sponsor of a bill, that bill can have multiple original cosponsors, or members who are listed as cosponsors on the date that a bill is introduced. Original cosponsorship is a signal of substantive legislative activity, more so than cosponsorship at other stages of the legislative process (Curry and Roberts 2023). While cosponsors can be added and removed to a bill through the entire legislative process, an original cosponsor is a member of Congress who was a cosponsor of the bill at the time of its introduction to the House floor. According to interviews conducted by Curry and Roberts (2023), original cosponsorship is often a serious indicator of legislative collaboration, and original cosponsors are typically considered to be equal partners on that piece of legislation. In other words, each original cosponsor of a bill likely put substantial effort into drafting that piece of legislation, so original cosponsorship demonstrates a high-effort legislative activity that represents a strong signal of commitment. As such, I rely on original cosponsorship as a measure of legislator activity, and ultimately campaign promise-keeping.[4] To collect data on original cosponsorship, I used Congress.gov's API to gather data on all bill introductions and cosponsorships in the House of Representatives for the

[4] I also report the results using a member's total cosponsorships as the dependent variable, and the conclusions remain consistent.

116th, 117th, and 118th Congress. The data from Congress.gov also lists whether a member of Congress was an original cosponsor on a given bill. Overall, I collected data on 143,914 original cosponsors from 34,607 bills introduced in the 116th-118th Congresses. I then use these data to evaluate campaign promisekeeping. Of course, not all of the 4,500 congressional candidates in my sample go on to win their electoral contests and gain a seat in the House of Representatives. As such, I can only evaluate the link between campaign appeals and legislative action for those candidates who won. Across 2018, 2020, and 2022, I have observations on the legislative activities for 1,306 candidates in my sample, so this becomes the basis of my analysis on biographical issue appeals and legislative promisekeeping.

Given that I am interested in explaining whether candidate biographical issue appeals on an issue lead to more legislative activity *on that issue*, I must identify what issue a campaign website statement is primarily discussing and also what related issue area a bill is about. The data from Porter, Case and Treul (2025) include a policy code, adapted from the Policy Agendas Project, for each candidate issue statement. While it is important to recognize that an issue statement can touch on more than one political issue, the coding in these data identifies one major policy area that an issue statement is primarily about. I rely on this coding for identifying the primary issue area of each candidate issue statement. Additionally, the data from Congress.gov provides a policy area term that is assigned to every bill and resolution introduced in Congress. The policy area assignment is done by legislative analysis in the Congressional Research Service, and the policy area term chosen is the one that best describes the primary focus of each measure.[5] Overall, the campaign website data link candidate issue statements on campaign websites to 13 policy codes, and the bills coding from CRS links bills to 32 major topic areas. However, there is significant overlap between the campaign website issue statement policy codes and the CRS policy areas. I rely on this overlap to map the bill policy areas to the policy codes from the campaign website data and use these linkages to determine if a candidate campaigned on policy area and then followed

[5]See CRS explanation for more information: https://www.congress.gov/help/field-values/policy-area

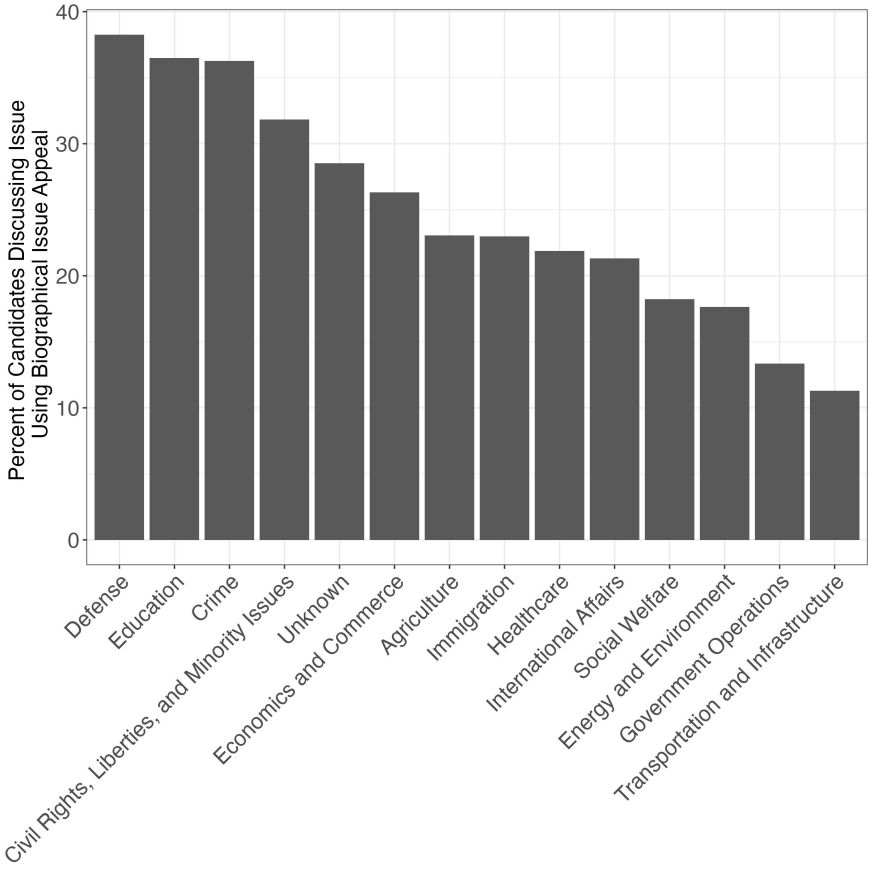
through on that campaign priority by sponsoring legislation in that major topic area. The specific coding scheme for linking policy areas to policy codes is presented in Table A6. Using this linkage as a guideline, I can then evaluate whether biographical issue appeals are related to more legislative action on that issue once in office.

Results

Before turning to the empirical models and testing my hypotheses, I will briefly present some descriptive statistics about the prevalence of biographical issue appeals within candidate issue statements. Overall, approximately 21% of all issue statements were classified as containing a biographical issue appeal. However, when aggregating the data from the statement-candidate-year level to the candidate-year level, 68% of all candidates engage in at least one biographical issue appeal in their campaign website issue platform. Of the candidates engaging in biographical issue appeals, candidates engage in between 1 and 20 of these appeals, with a median of 2 and a mean of 3 biographical issue appeals on a candidate's campaign website. Additionally, 70% of those candidates engaging in these appeals have between 1 and 3 biographical issue appeals on their campaign website.

There is also great variation regarding the issue areas candidates are more likely to talk about when using biographical issue appeals. A breakdown of the frequency with which candidates engage in biographical issue appeals on each of the major policy areas is presented below in Figure 1. When examining this figure, the results appear to line up with common sense expectations of which major policy areas are more conducive to biographical issue appeals. For example, given the nature of the topics, it makes sense that far more candidates would engage in a biographical issue appeal on the topic of education than on infrastructure.

Figure 1: Percent of Candidates Engaging in Biographical Issue Appeals by Issue Area



Candidate Usage of Biographical Issue Appeals

To test my hypotheses surrounding which candidates will engage in biographical issue appeals and under what electoral conditions, I run a logistic regression model in which the outcome variable is a binary variable for whether or not a candidate engages in a biographical issue appeal on her campaign website. To code this variable, a candidate receives a value of 1 if any of her campaign website issue statements in a given election cycle contain a biographical issue appeal. If none of a candidate's issue statements were classified as a biographical issue appeal, then that candidate receives a 0. The key independent variable to test H1 about electoral competition is a binary variable for district competitiveness based on the previous presidential vote share in that district. Districts in which the Democratic presidential candidate won between 45% and 55% of the two party vote share are classified

as competitive, and districts that are safe for either the Democratic or Republican party are considered safe districts. To test hypotheses H2 and H3, the independent variables of interest are candidate experience and candidate fundraising (which serves as a proxy for candidate quality). To test H2 and H3, I utilize a factor variable to indicate whether a candidate is the incumbent legislator, a candidate with previous elected experience, or an inexperienced candidate. To test H2, I also use data from the FEC website to measure candidate fundraising. Specifically, I focus on candidate fundraising prior to the date of the primary election, or preprimary receipts. This allows me to focus only on the campaign funds that a candidate received prior to the primary election and ignore the funds that a candidate may have raised after winning a primary election and demonstrating their viability as a candidate. Rather than use the raw value of preprimary receipts, I use the logged value of preprimary receipts for each candidate. For candidates who did not receive any campaign contributions, I hold their fundraising value at zero, rather than taking the log. In addition to the independent variables of interest, I also control for a number of other factors related to both candidate characteristics and electoral conditions that may influence the likelihood a candidate engages in a biographical issue appeal. For candidate characteristics, I include a binary variable for whether or not a candidate is female and for whether or not a candidate is Black. Related to electoral conditions, I control for primary election type and whether or not a primary election is contested (features more than one candidate). To measure primary type, I classify each type of primary election into partisan or non-partisan. Non-partisan primaries are primary elections in which Democratic and Republican candidates compete together in the same field. These non-partisan primaries include states with top-two and top-four primaries as well as Louisiana, which holds a single election on election day rather than a primary election. All other types of primary election (open, closed, and partially-closed) are classified as partisan primaries. I also cluster standard errors at the candidate level to account for dependencies within-candidate across years. The results of the logistic regression are presented in Table 2.

The results from this model indicate support for my hypotheses. In support of H1 relating

Table 2: Candidates Engaging In Biographical Issue Appeals

	Dependent variable:
	Presence of Biographical Issue Appeal
Competitive District	0.276^{***}
	(0.088)
Experienced Candidate	0.289^{**}
Ref: Incumbent	(0.154)
Inexperienced Candidate	-0.338^{***}
Ref: Incumbent	(0.123)
Fundraising	0.075^{***}
	(0.008)
Female	0.116
	(0.086)
Black	-0.461^{***}
	(0.114)
Republican	-0.128^{*}
	(0.078)
Partisan Primary	0.058
	(0.111)
Contested Primary	-0.162
	(0.103)
Constant	0.406^{**}
	(0.197)
Year Fixed Effects	✓
Observations	4,502
Note:	*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

to candidates in competitive districts, candidates in competitive districts are approximately five percentage points more likely to utilize a biographical issue appeal on the issue page of their campaign website than candidates running in safe districts ($p<0.01$). This suggests that candidates, particularly those who face a tough general election battle, will engage in biographical issue appeals, perhaps as a method of broadening their messaging across party lines in order to secure enough votes to achieve victory. My hypotheses related to candidate quality and candidate experience also receive support. In support of H2 relating to high-quality candidates, candidate quality appears to be related to the likelihood that a candidate engages in a biographical issue appeal in their campaign website rhetoric. Candidates who are stronger fundraisers are more likely to utilize biographical issue appeals ($p<0.01$), and both incumbents and challengers with previous political experience are more likely than political amateurs to leverage biographical issue appeals in their issue platform ($p<.05$). There is also evidence suggesting that, consistent with H3, challengers with previous political experience are more likely to utilize biographical issue appeals on their campaign website than incumbents ($p<0.05$). Perhaps this is because incumbent candidates are largely engaged in credit claiming in their campaign communications and do not need to rely on their background outside of their job as the current member of Congress.

Biographical Issue Appeals and Legislative Follow-Through

I model the relationship between campaign appeals and legislative activity in the subsequent Congress for candidates who won election to the House of Representatives in 2018, 2020, and 2022. In this model, I evaluate whether those who use biographical issue appeals on an issue are more likely to follow through in office than candidates who campaign on that issue without including a biographical issue appeal. To model this, I use a negative binomial model in which the outcome variable is a count of the number of original cosponsorships per member of Congress per policy area. The key independent variables for this analysis are two indicators demonstrating whether the member campaigned on that issue and whether the

member campaigned on that issue using a biographical issue appeal. In this model, I also include member-year fixed effects and policy area fixed effects. The policy area fixed effects account for the fact that some policy areas receive much more action in Congress than others. For example, in the 116th Congress there were 1,337 bill introductions on the topic of health (with 11,777 original cosponsors), but only 227 on the topic of energy (with 1,547 original cosponsors). Including policy area fixed effects accounts for the different baseline levels of bill introductions and cosponsorships that each policy area has. In addition to policy area fixed effects, I also include member-year fixed effects. This means a member of Congress serving in the 116th, 117th, and 118th Congresses would have three different fixed effects. These fixed effects allow to control for unobserved, time-invariant and time-varying characteristics that may impact a member of Congress' level of legislative activity (e.g., majority party status). By including member-year fixed effects, I am essentially comparing a member's behavior to themselves on other issues in that particular year. The results of the negative binomial model, in which the unit of observations is the member-year-policy area, are presented in Table 3.

Table 3: Biographical Issue Appeals and Legislative Activity, 116th-118th Congress

	Dependent variable:	
	Original Cosponsorships	Total Cosponsorhips
Issue Appeal	0.297^{***}	0.275^{***}
	(0.016)	(0.014)
Biographical Issue Appeal	0.097^{***}	0.083^{***}
	(0.019)	(0.017)
Constant	-0.285	0.386
	(0.263)	(0.221)
Member-Year Fixed Effects	✓	✓
Policy Area Fixed Effects	✓	✓
Observations	14,716	14,716
Note:		*p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001

Beginning with the issue appeal variable, the results from this model suggest that members of Congress who mention an issue on the campaign trail are original cosponsors of significantly more bills on that issue in Congress ($p<0.001$). In substantive terms, members of Congress who discuss an issue on their campaign website are original cosponsors of approximately two more bills on that issue area than members who do not include an issue statement on that issue in their campaign platform (which represents a 34% increase in original cosponsorships on an issue). This finding is consistent with the work of Sulkin (2009) and suggests that issue statements on campaign websites are indeed strong signals of a candidates' legislative priorities and activities once in office. Turning to the biographical issue appeals variable, when controlling for policy area and the specific qualities and characteristics of an individual member in a given Congress, a candidate engaging in a biographical issue appeal on an issue is associated with a significant increase in the number of original cosponsorships that a member pursues on that issue ($p<0.001$). Controlling for whether a member of Congress campaigns on an issue, members of Congress who utilize a biographical issue appeal on their campaign website have a predicted increase of 0.5 more original cosponsorships on that issue (a 10% increase). This finding suggests that beyond candidates who make generic or impersonal campaign statements on an issue, candidates who use a biographical issue appeal are more likely to be legislatively active on that issue. By explicitly linking their background to a policy stance, candidates provide a high-intensity signal of commitment that exceeds the baseline effect of merely including an issue statement on their platform. This indicates that biographical issue appeals are indeed a heightened signal of commitment, and that a candidate is likely to follow through on those issues once in office.

To further examine whether the increase in legislative activity is associated with the background experience itself or the strategic choice to highlight that experience on during campaign, I conduct an exploratory analysis focusing on military veterans. This allows me to begin testing H8 by holding a background characteristic constant and examining the variation

in how candidates chose to message on that background. Specifically, among candidates who share the same biographical experience (service in the military), does the act of utilizing a biographical issue appeal on defense-related issues predict a higher level of legislative follow-through than simply possessing veteran status?

To test this, I subset the data to include only the military veterans who won election to the House of Representatives in 2022. I then restrict the analysis specifically to the policy area of defense. This results in a very small sample size ($N = 66$ members), and as such, these results should be interpreted as a preliminary look at this mechanism.[6] Consistent with the primary model, I use a negative binomial regression to evaluate the relationship between biographical issue appeals among veterans and subsequent legislative activity on defense. The results of this preliminary analysis are presented in Table 4.

Table 4: Biographical Issue Appeals and Legislative Activity, Veterans on Defense Bills in 118th Congress

	Dependent variable:	
	Original Cosponsorships	Total Cosponsorships
Issue Appeal	−0.244	−0.148
	(0.273)	(0.260)
Biographical Issue Appeal	0.654**	0.558*
	(0.244)	(0.232)
Constant	2.065***	2.670***
	(0.164)	(0.159)
Observations	66	66
Note:	*p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001	

The results of this exploratory analysis suggest that even among a group of individuals who share a significant life experience, the strategic choice to utilize that experience in

[6]This analysis currently focuses on military veterans and the policy area of defense as a clear and identifiable background-to-issue link. I plan to expand this analysis to include other professional backgrounds and their corresponding policy domains, such as educators on education policy and healthcare workers on healthcare policy, to further evaluate the generalizability of these findings.

campaign rhetoric is a meaningful predictor of legislative behavior. Among veterans in the 118th Congress, those who utilized a biographical issue appeal on the issue of defense during their 2022 campaign were associated with a significant increase in original cosponsorships on defense bills compared to veterans who campaigned on defense without an explicit biographical link. This provides initial support for H8, suggesting that the biographical issue appeal functions as a distinct, high-intensity commitment that goes beyond a candidate's resume or baseline interests. Ultimately, the power of the biographical issue appeal appears to stem from the strategic choice to highlight a background to the electorate, rather than merely the reflection of the background itself, although a more robust analysis is still required.

Conclusion

This paper has explored the strategic use, perception, and legislative reality of biographical issue appeals (BIAs) in contemporary American politics. Through a large-scale analysis of campaign websites and legislative activity, I find that biographical issue appeals are not a niche rhetorical device but a prolific strategy in modern congressional campaigning, utilized by nearly 70% of candidates. Far from being a peripheral distraction, these appeals serve as a high-intensity signal of commitment that bridges the gap between a candidate's personal identity and their legislative agenda. Furthermore, these signals represent a depth of intent that exceeds standard campaigning; the follow-through analysis demonstrates that when a candidate utilizes a biographical issue appeal, they are significantly more likely to prioritize that issue once in office.

The results presented here offer a new perspective on the ongoing debate regarding the personalization of politics. While many scholars fear that a shift toward personalistic politics undermines democratic representation, my findings suggest that personalism can actually facilitate accountability. By fusing together their personal experiences with policy priorities, when candidates use biographical issue appeals voters are provided with an essential informa-

tional anchor. These appeals may allow voters to discern which of the many policy promises a candidate is most likely to prioritize once in office.

The legislative follow-through analysis demonstrates that these signals are not hollow. Members of Congress who utilize biographical issue appeals are significantly more likely to engage in meaningful legislative activity on those issues than on issues where they offered impersonal stances or did not campaign at all. As my exploratory analysis of military veterans suggests, this effect is not merely a reflection of a candidate's resume, but a result of the strategic choice to highlight that experience on the campaign trail. This act of messaging creates a public contract with the voter, making the BIA a potent tool for substantive representation. A logical next step for this research would be to investigate the qualitative content of this follow-through, examining whether BIAs lead to different types of legislative interventions or more specialized bill language tailored to the candidate's specific area of expertise and interest.

While this project establishes the broad prevalence and effectiveness of biographical issue appeals, there is significant room to explore the heterogeneity of these appeals. My findings indicate that the use of BIAs is not uniform; for example, Black candidates are significantly less likely to utilize these appeals than their white counterparts. These findings suggest several questions for future research. For example, does the usage and effectiveness of a BIA vary when candidates run in majority-minority versus majority-white districts? Furthermore, are the effects of biographical issue appeal usage gendered? If a woman invokes a biographical link to a traditionally masculine issue like defense or trade, is she perceived with the same experiential authority as a man doing the same? There is also work to be done in categorizing the types of BIAs and their effectiveness. For example, is a candidate's occupational experience perceived differently than a personal hardship she overcame? It may be that different categories of experience signal different types of competence or different levels of commitment, and that certain narratives resonate more effectively with voters than others.

This project also raises future questions about studying legislative individualism in

Congress. If biographical issue appeals are indeed high-intensity signals for future behavior, they should influence not just cosponsorship, but other aspects of the legislative process as well. Future work should evaluate the relationship between BIA usage and committee assignments, as candidates may seek specific jurisdictions to fulfill the biographical mandates they established on the trail. Additionally, we might look at "outlier" members of Congress to see if their independence can be explained by their personal experiences or the high-intensity signals they send to their constituents. Another critical next step also involves looking at behavior beyond the subsequent Congress. Does the impact of these appeals fade over time, or do members continue to draw on these biographical anchors in their speeches and prioritize the related issues throughout their tenure in Congress?

Finally, with a wider variety of backgrounds and a rise in inexperienced candidates achieving electoral success (Porter and Treul 2024), it is vital to understand what this increasing diversity of experience in Congress means for congressional organization. As more members enter the chamber with non-traditional backgrounds, the way they utilize their biographies to stake out policy territory may fundamentally alter the role of committees and the broader structure of legislative specialization.

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Appendix A

Supervised Machine Learning Pipeline

The complete supervised machine learning pipeline I use to classify biographical issue appeals in candidate campaign websites is as follows. I hand labeled a random sample of 5,429 candidate issue statements to determine whether a candidate engaged in a biographical issue appeal in that particular issue statement. Rather than labeling each issue statement as a binary of whether a candidate engaged in a biographical issue appeal or not, I separated the text to the paragraph level to add more granularity to the identification of biographical issue appeals. Issue statements are often several paragraphs long and it is common that a biographical issue appeal is contained within a single paragraph in an issue statement. As such, I hand-labled 17,347 paragraphs (from the 5,429 issue statements) for whether a candidate engaged in a biographical issue appeal in that particular paragraph. As mentioned, the data contain 43,495 issue statements (142,839 paragraphs) from over 4,500 congressional candidates. It is therefore not feasible to indentify these biographical issue appeals entirely by hand. Instead, I take advantage of recent advancements in machine learning to classify candidate issue statements as being biographical issue appeals or not.

To do this, I first divide my hand labeled data into a training set and a validation set. Of the 17,347 issue statement paragraphs I hand labeled, I use 14,797 paragraphs (85%) as training data and 2,550 paragraphs (15%) as validation data. Because my classification task is a nuanced language task, I rely on OpenAI's "text-embedding-3-small" model to generate a representation of the text for each individual issue statement paragraph using a transformer architecture. Embeddings are a numerical representation of text in a high dimensional space that capture the overall context and semantic meaning of each issue statement paragraph. Using these contextualized embeddings enables me to capture nuanced language properties that could not be captured by a bag-of-words representation, including the nuanced language candidates use to engage in a biographical issue appeal. I use the embeddings for each of the paragraphs in my training data as the input for training five different machine learning models to predict whether a paragraph is a biographical issue appeal. Following recommendations from Rodriguez and Spirling (2022), I engage in minimal text preprocessing. I then use these embeddings to train five classification models: support vector machine, random forest, gradient boosting, ridge regression, and lasso regression. For all models, I select model parameters using a 5-fold cross validation grid search. For each of the five candidate models, I make out-of-sample predictions for all unlabeled issue statement paragraphs as well as the 2,550 paragraphs that were held out as a validation set. Validation metrics for each of the five candidate models are presented in Table A5.

I select the machine learning model, support vector machine (SVM) that performs best on the classification of the target class, biographical issue appeals, and take steps to improve the model's performance. Specifically, I select the 500 edge cases closest to the decision boundary and hand label those paragraphs. I then add those newly hand labeled paragraphs to my initial training data and re-train each of the five candidate models with the updated training data while still performing 5-fold cross validation grid search to select model parameters. I then make out-of-sample predictions for all unlabeled issue statement paragraphs as well as the same 2,550 paragraphs that serve as a held out validation set. The output

generated from each of the five models is a binary variable indicating whether or not an issue statement paragraph is a biographical issue appeal. I use the outputs generated by the best performing model, SVM (F1 = 0.784), for the analyses relating to H1-H3. Specifically, I use the paragraph-level predictions and aggregate the paragraphs back up to the statement level to determine whether an individual issue statement contains a biographical issue appeal.

Table A5: Out-of-Sample Validation Metrics of Biographical Issue Appeals Classification

	Accuracy	Precision	Recall	F1
SVM	0.966	0.745	0.827	0.784
Ridge	0.945	0.587	0.880	0.704
Gradient Boost	0.945	0.606	0.780	0.682
Lasso	0.766	0.254	0.989	0.404
Random Forest	0.939	0.790	0.257	0.387

Appendix B

Table A6: Mapping Issue Statement Policy Codes to Bill Policy Areas

Website Policy Code	**Congressional Reasearch Service Policy Area**
Agriculture	Agriculture and Food
Civil Rights and Liberties	Civil Rights and Liberties, Minority Issues; Native Americans
Crime	Crime and Law Enforcement
Defense	Armed Forces and National Security
Economics and Commerce	Economics and Public Finance; Commerce; Finance and Financial Sector; Taxation; Foreign Trade and International Finance
Education	Education
Energy and Environment	Energy, Environmental Protection, Public Lands and Natural Resources
Government Operations	Congress; Government Operations and Politics
Healthcare	Health
International Affairs	International Affairs
Immigration	Immigration
Social Welfare	Housing and Community Development; Social Welfare; Families
Transportation and Infrastructure	Transportation and Public Works; Water Resources Development